Chronology template

For a parent preparing a short, dated account of child arrangements for the family court in England and Wales. Free to print, copy and adapt. Rules checked 30 September 2026.

Why a chronology, not the whole diary

Since 2 March 2026, Practice Direction 27A says “notes of contact visits” must not go in the court bundle unless the court directs otherwise (paragraph 5.2(e)). What the court does read is short: a chronology is capped at **10 pages** (paragraph 8.1), and where one is prepared for a hearing each entry is to be “limited, if practicable, to one sentence and cross-referenced to the relevant page(s) in the bundle” (paragraph 7.10(f)). Your diary or app stays with you; this sheet carries the dates that matter.

In proceedings the chronology in the bundle is meant to be a single document agreed between the parties, with any disagreement set out at the relevant places (paragraph 7.15). Usually the applicant takes the lead in preparing it (paragraph 7.9). Your own chronology is the careful working draft you bring to that, and the backbone of your statement.

How to fill it in

1. **One row per event, in date order.** Only events that bear on the question the court is deciding.
2. **What was arranged:** what the order or written agreement said for that date, with the times, and where it comes from (for example “order of 3 Feb 2026, para 2”).
3. **What happened:** one sentence of plain fact. Actual times. What you saw yourself; if someone told you, say who.
4. **Source / ref.:** where the fact can be checked, such as your diary entry for that day. Once the bundle is paginated, add its page reference (for example “C14”).
5. **Include what went well** where it matters. A run of visits that happened on time is the baseline that gives a missed one its meaning.
6. **Keep it neutral.** No opinions about the other parent, no guesses about motives, no adjectives, no scores.
7. **Fill in the heading.** The date you prepared it and the date of the hearing it is for go on the front (paragraph 7.13).
8. **Keep it short.** Ten pages is the ceiling, not the target. If a row does not help decide the issue, leave it out.

A worked example (fictional)

No.	Date	What was arranged	What happened (one sentence of fact)	Source / ref.
1	Sat 7 Mar 2026	Contact 10:00–17:00 (order of 3 Feb 2026, para 2)	Took place. Collected 10:05, returned 17:00.	Diary, 7 Mar
2	Sat 14 Mar 2026	Contact 10:00–17:00 (as above)	Did not take place. Message received 08:40 saying A was unwell.	Diary, 14 Mar; message 08:40
3	Sat 21 Mar 2026	Contact 10:00–17:00 (as above)	Moved by agreement to Sun 22 Mar; took place 10:00–17:00.	Diary, 21–22 Mar

Every detail in the example is invented. Notice what it leaves out: why the visit was missed, how anyone felt, and anything nobody saw.

This template is general information about keeping records, not legal advice. It does not say that any document will be accepted by a court; that is for the court in each case. If you are in proceedings, take advice about your own situation. Source: Practice Direction 27A, Family Proceedings: Court Bundles, justice.gov.uk.

Chronology

Case name / number		Prepared by	
Date prepared		Hearing date	
Child(ren)		Period covered	

No.	Date	What was arranged	What happened (one sentence of fact)	Source / ref.

Chronology (continued)

Case name / number: _____ Page ____ of ____

No.	Date	What was arranged	What happened (one sentence of fact)	Source / ref.